

THE ART OF THE WET FLY

2-Day Curriculum · Student Handout

14

Sessions

~9 hrs

On-water time

4

Method pillars

2

Full days

Traditional Swing · Davy Wotton Induced Method · Dead Drift Wet · Contact / Evolutionary

"The big advantage with these techniques is they empower the angler to really grid off massive amounts of water much quicker than any other method. That is the art — systematic coverage, not random casting."

Quick reference

FOUR METHODS AT A GLANCE

Traditional swing	Quarter-downstream cast on floating line, upstream mend, low rod track, let fly hang — step-and-swing grid covers all water.
Dead drift wet	Upstream 45° cast, high rod tracks fly downstream at current speed with zero tension. Most demanding line control in fly fishing.
Wotton induced method	Upstream, across, and downstream presentations with a cast of flies. Leisenring Lift at target lie triggers instinctive take.
Contact / evolutionary	Tight-line swing with gentle fly animation. Straight-down feed for unreachable lies. Rod-tap pulses for movement.

METHOD BY WATER TYPE

Riffles (1–3 ft)	Traditional swing on floating line — textured surface conceals approach, fast enough for active swing
Tailouts / pool tails	Slow swing on floating or intermediate — flies rise through depth at hang — prime strike zone
Pool heads	Dead drift or Wotton upstream — high energy, flies sink quickly; let current do the work
Inside bends & seams	Contact technique or guided swing — rod tip steers fly around obstacles impossible to reach by casting
Boulder pockets	Wotton upstream + Leisenring Lift OR contact straight-down feed into the slot
Slow flats	Dead drift only — swing accelerates fly unacceptably; intermediate line to keep fly in zone

PATTERNS & CAST OF FLIES LOGIC

Winged wets (point fly)	Leadwing Coachman, Hare's Ear wet, March Brown wet, Royal Coachman wet — weight and profile
Soft hackles (dropper)	Partridge & Orange, Starling & Herl, Pheasant Tail soft hackle — pulsing tier, mobile in current
SA originals	Tellico, Yallerhammer, Jim Charley, Thunderhead, Crackleback — attractor logic, regional heritage
Attractor hairwings	Soft Hackle Coachman, Green Weenie wet, Crackleback — general suggestion, no hatch needed
Hatch-shift patterns	Yellow Sally soft hackle, BWO soft hackle, Elk Hair Caddis wet — when prolific hatch changes the game
Cast of flies logic	Point: heaviest/most suggestive · Middle dropper: lighter attractor · Top dropper: smallest/lightest

STRIKE DETECTION BY METHOD

Traditional swing	Jolting take on tight line — fish often hook themselves; shock loop absorbs explosive takes
Dead drift wet	Subtle pull or tick — raise rod immediately; no tension in system until you create it
Wotton Leisenring Lift	Confident take as fly rises — fish commits, no refusal behavior; lift firmly, don't strike hard
Contact / straight-down	Line-tip deviation, slight tick, or rod-load sensation — subtle; requires total focus on line angle

ROD & GEAR SELECTION

Rod action	Mid-flex or soft-tip 9.5–11 ft in 3–4 wt. Soft tip cushions takes, loads roll cast, works the flies without drying them.
Why not fast action	Fast-action rods dry flies on false casts, create shock on tight-line takes that break tippet, and fight the soft presentation.
Floating line	Ideal for classic swing in 1–3 ft water. Best control, easiest mending, most visibility.
Intermediate line	For water 3–5 ft or slow pools. Gets flies down without the hinge of a sink tip. Slime line or clear camo.
Leader length	12–16 ft total on a 5X base. Longer leaders keep fly line off the water in the Wotton method.
Dropper spacing	20–30" between droppers, open-loop uni-knot on each fly for maximum pulsing movement.

Day 1 — Gear, swing & the traditional method

7:30 – 8:30 am

Welcome, wet fly philosophy & the big advantage

PHILOSOPHY

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand the four-method framework: traditional, Wotton induced, dead drift, contact
- Articulate the water-coverage advantage of wet fly over any other method
- Distinguish wet fly from nymph in philosophy and presentation intent
- Set up gear philosophy: why rod action and line choice matter before the first cast

KEY CONCEPTS

Traditional swing: oldest trout technique still standing ♦ Dead drift wet: most demanding line control in fly fishing ♦ Wotton induced: active upstream, a cast of flies, all quadrants ♦ Contact/evolutionary: tight-line swing hybrid ♦ The grid advantage: step-and-swing covers every seam systematically ♦ Soft hackle materials breathe and pulse — the fly does the work

ACTIVITIES

- Group discussion: have you swung a wet fly? What happened?
- Brief lineage: Dame Juliana Berners 1496 → Nemes 1975 → Wotton today
- Instructor demonstration: step-and-swing gridding a riffle run vs. nymphing the same water — time and fish contact compared

M B *“The big advantage with wet fly techniques is they empower the angler to grid off massive amounts of water much quicker than any other method. That alone makes this worth mastering before any other subsurface approach.”*

8:30 – 10:00 am

Rod action, line choice & leader building for wet flies

GEAR

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Select the right rod action for wet fly work and explain why fast action fights the method
- Build a wet fly leader with correct dropper spacing for a cast of two or three flies
- Match floating line vs. intermediate to water depth and swing speed
- Understand why longer rods and mid-flex actions serve wet fly presentation

KEY CONCEPTS

Mid-flex soft-tip 10 ft 3–4 wt: cushions takes, loads roll cast, works the flies ♦ Fast-action rods dry flies, create shock on tight-line takes ♦ Roll cast and single-hand Spey: primary casts — no high back-cast needed ♦ Floating line: control and visibility for 1–3 ft water ♦ Intermediate line: depth without sink-tip hinge ♦ Leader: 12–16 ft total, 5X base, surgeon's loop droppers 20–30" apart ♦ Point fly: heaviest; upper dropper: lighter attractor; top dropper: smallest ♦ Open-loop uni-knot on all flies for maximum movement

ACTIVITIES

- Bench session: build a Wotton-style three-fly leader — surgeon's loops, correct spacing, open-loop fly attachment
- Roll cast drill with assembled leader: smooth turnover without tangling droppers
- Line comparison on flat water: floating vs. intermediate — observe sink rate and swing speed difference

M B *“Wet fly actioned rods for roll casting and rod actions to fish wets are a real consideration. A soft-tip mid-flex rod loads on a short stroke, protects fine tippets on hard takes, and works the flies without drying them.”*

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student's three-fly leader must turn over cleanly on a roll cast without tangling. Instructor checks knot integrity and dropper spacing before water work.

10:00 – 10:15 am — Break & walk to water

10:15 am – 12:00 pm

Traditional wet fly method — the down-and-across swing

TRADITIONAL

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Execute the classic quarter-downstream cast and swing on floating line
- Control swing speed with upstream mends without losing tension
- Read water for swing lies: riffles, tailouts, seams, inside bends
- Step-and-swing systematically through a run, covering every lane

KEY CONCEPTS

Quarter-downstream cast: 45° angle to current — not straight across ♦ Upstream mend immediately after landing: allows fly to sink before tensioning ♦ Belly management: mend to slow swing; lead rod tip to speed it ♦ Rod tip low, tracking the fly through the arc ♦ The hang: fly rises at end of swing, imitating emergence — most strikes here ♦ Step-and-swing grid: two steps downstream after each cast ♦ Shock loop: 8–12" of line held between fingers — absorbs explosive takes ♦ Strikes on tight line: fish often hook themselves

ACTIVITIES

- First-swing drill: quarter cast, immediate upstream mend, low rod tip track, hang for 5-count
- Step-and-swing grid: student covers 30-yard riffle run top to bottom — instructor confirms systematic coverage
- Speed control: mend to slow, lead rod to speed — student feels the difference in fly behavior
- Hang drill: hold the fly at the hang for a full 5-count before recasting

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student grids a full riffle run using step-and-swing without missing lanes. Instructor checks swing speed — not a torpedo, not a stall.

12:00 – 12:45 pm — Lunch on the river

12:45 – 2:30 pm

Wet fly patterns — attractors, soft hackles & the cast of flies

PATTERNS

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand why attractors dominate in Southern Appalachia vs. specific imitations
- Identify key wet fly categories: winged wets, soft hackles, hairwings, Southern Appalachian originals
- Build a cast of flies with logical point/dropper logic
- Know when to shift toward imitation during a prolific hatch

KEY CONCEPTS

Attractors first in Appalachian water — suggestive, not exact ♦ Winged wets: Leadwing Coachman, Hare's Ear wet, March Brown, Royal Coachman ♦ Soft hackles: Partridge & Orange, Starling & Herl, Pheasant Tail soft hackle ♦ Southern Appalachian originals: Tellico, Yallerhammer, Jim Charley, Thunderhead, Crackleback ♦ Cast of flies logic: point heaviest, middle dropper lighter, top dropper smallest ♦ Hatch-matching shift: Yellow Sallies or BWOs → imitative soft hackle on dropper

ACTIVITIES

- Fly board sort: organize patterns into attractor / suggestive / imitative — justify each placement
- Cast of flies build: assemble three-fly rig for today's water type and conditions
- Water observation and bankside hatch watch: does anything suggest a hatch shift?

M B *"Patterns of wets tend to usually be attractors in my part of the country unless there is a prolific hatch. The Tellico, the Yallerhammer — Southern Appalachian originals that have worked here for generations. Start there."*

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student correctly assigns point and dropper flies with logical reasoning for today's conditions. Instructor validates the logic before fishing.

2:30 – 4:00 pm

Day 1 debrief, water reading & Day 2 preview

REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Consolidate swing mechanics and line control from the day
- Learn to read water specifically for wet fly coverage — not for a single fish
- Introduce dead drift and Wotton method concepts before Day 2
- Self-assess swing speed control, step-and-swing discipline, and hang patience

KEY CONCEPTS

Riffles: prime swing water — textured surface hides approach ♦ Tailouts: slow swing, flies rise from depth — classic hang-strike zone ♦ Inside bends and seams: prime holding lies for wet fly swing ♦ Pool heads: high energy, flies get depth quickly with mend ♦ Dead drift wet: flies drift naturally upstream, no tension — hardest line control ♦ Wotton upstream: flies fished in all quadrants, not just down and across

ACTIVITIES

- Water reading walk: identify three wet fly lie types — student explains the approach for each
- Day 1 self-assessment: swing speed, dropper tangles, hang patience, pattern logic
- Preview Day 2: dead drift technique, Wotton upstream and induced methods, contact evolution

✓ **Checkpoint:** Students correctly identify and describe the swing approach for three lie types, and articulate what made their hang discipline strong or weak today.

Day 2 — Dead drift, Wotton & contact evolution

7:30 – 8:30 am

Dead drift wet fly — the most demanding line control in fly fishing

DEAD DRIFT

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand why dead drifting a wet fly demands more line control than any other presentation
- Execute an upstream cast with a sinking wet fly and achieve a natural, tension-free drift
- Manage the high rod, leading the drift without creating drag
- Know when the dead drift ends and the swing begins — and how to use that transition

KEY CONCEPTS

Dead drift: fly drifts at exactly current speed with zero line tension ♦ Upstream 45° cast: fly and leader land above target, fly sinks as it comes toward you ♦ High rod tracks the drift: tip follows line downstream, no slack, no tension ♦ Strike detection without indicator: feel, watch the leader, watch the fly line tip ♦ Transition to swing: as fly passes and line tightens, fly rises — natural emergence ♦ Why it's hardest: fly invisible, tension invisible, drag invisible ♦ Upstream mend on dead drift: repositioning line without moving the fly ♦ Short drifts are effective drifts: pick up and recast upstream, don't chase

ACTIVITIES

- Upstream dead drift drill on slow flat water: track fly with rod, feel for takes
- Partner observation: one drifts, partner watches leader for micro-drag — call every deviation
- Transition drill: let dead drift become the swing naturally — call the moment of tension onset

M B *"The dead drift wet fly technique is among the most difficult — dependent entirely on line control. No indicator, no visual cue — just feel, rod angle, and a disciplined upstream cast."*

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student achieves a minimum 8-second tension-free dead drift in a moderate current seam. Partner confirms with bankside observation of line behavior.

8:30 – 10:15 am

Davy Wotton's induced method — upstream active wet fly

WOTTON METHOD

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand the Wotton philosophy: present flies to every quadrant of the stream
- Execute upstream, across-stream, and downstream Wotton presentations with a cast of flies
- Apply the induced take — Leisenring Lift — at a targeted fish position
- Use rod angle and hang angle to animate and control the cast of flies

KEY CONCEPTS

Wotton upstream: cast up and across, high-stick the drift, animate with rod-tip pulses ♦ All four quadrants: upstream, across, down-and-across, straight down — each fished differently ♦ Induced take / Leisenring Lift: check rod 4 ft above target — fly rises naturally on current pressure ♦ Hang angle: rod position from 12 to 3 o'clock controls fly depth and movement ♦ Figure-8 retrieve: controlled loop retrieve for across and downstream presentations ♦ Rod-tip animation: subtle pulses give flies lifelike movement without drag ♦ 10 ft+ rod advantage: reach, line mending, and hang-angle control all improve with length ♦ Cast of flies on the lift: point on bottom, upper dropper rises first

ACTIVITIES

- Four-quadrant drill: fish same piece of water from all four angles — instructor assesses coverage
- Induced take setup: target a visible holding fish, execute upstream drift and Leisenring Lift at exact position
- Hang angle practice: vary rod from 12 to 3 o'clock during swing — feel how it changes fly behavior
- Figure-8 retrieve drill: across-stream cast, smooth figure-8 back — no clunks or pauses

M B *"Davy Wotton brings a method practically unknown in North America — presenting flies to every quadrant of the stream. The induced take is the centerpiece. The fish doesn't choose to refuse; the fly rises away from it, triggering an instinctive take."*

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student executes a successful Leisenring Lift at a visible holding spot. Instructor assesses whether the lift was triggered by current or by the angler jerking the rod.

10:15 – 10:30 am — Break

10:30 am – 12:00 pm

Contact & evolutionary wet fly — tight-line swing hybrid

CONTACT

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand contact wet fly as the evolutionary bridge between traditional swing and tight-line nymphing
- Fish a wet fly on a tight contact line without the fly accelerating unnaturally
- Execute the straight-down feeding technique for bends and logjam reaches
- Use rod-tip pulses and line animation to build movement without drag

KEY CONCEPTS

Contact: tight line to fly with zero tension — not drag, not slack — the hardest balance ♦ Straight-down feed: strip line in 4-inch pulls, fly dances downstream into unreachable lies ♦ Rod-tip animation: tap rod blank during swing — sends vibration pulses into soft hackle fibers ♦ Swing with induced movement: controlled rhythm of tension and release ♦ Point fly behavior: watch the line tip, not the fly — line angle is your indicator ♦ Covering complex water: contact guides fly around bends, through slots, under banks ♦ Euro nymphing kinship: same tight-line philosophy, different flies and swing arc ♦ Step-and-contact grid: more granular coverage than traditional swing

ACTIVITIES

- Straight-down feed drill: student feeds line downstream into pool tail or bend — guide with rod tip to target lie
- Rod-tap animation: feel the difference between vibration reaching the fly vs. the rod absorbing it
- Complex water coverage: use contact technique to fish a slot behind a boulder unreachable by quartering cast
- Partner read: one fishes contact, partner watches line tip behavior and calls subtle takes

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student successfully guides a fly into at least one complex lie using the straight-down feed or contact technique, and detects one subtle take through line behavior.

12:00 – 12:45 pm — Lunch

12:45 – 2:30 pm

Applied wet fly — gridding off water, reading lies & method selection

APPLIED

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Choose the correct wet fly method for a given water type and lie
- Grid a run efficiently from top to bottom using the appropriate technique
- Detect takes across all four methods: jolting swing, dead drift pull, Wotton lift, contact line twitch
- Self-direct a 30-minute independent water session without instructor coaching

KEY CONCEPTS

Method matching: riffle tail → traditional swing; pool head → dead drift; boulder slot → contact; rising fish above → Wotton ♦ Grid discipline: no random casting — cover every seam before moving ♦ Take detection: jolting swing vs. subtle dead-drift pull vs. Wotton lift vs. contact twitch ♦ Setting on swing: don't strike — let line tighten, then lift firmly ♦ Setting on dead drift: raise the rod immediately — no tension until you create it ♦ Switching methods mid-run: when swing draws no takes, try dead drift on same water

ACTIVITIES

- Method-selection walk: 5 water features, students call the correct method and justify
- Full run coverage: student grids 40-yard run top to bottom, self-selecting method by section
- Independent session: 30 minutes on assigned water — no coaching, self-report on methods used and takes detected

M B *“The big advantage is real — grid off massive amounts of water much quicker than any other method. But only if you fish it with discipline. Random casting with a wet fly is just splashing. Systematic coverage is the art.”*

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student covers their assigned run systematically and debriefs: which method per section, why, and what their takes felt or looked like.

2:30 – 4:00 pm

Final debrief, written assessment & path forward

REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Synthesize the two-day arc across all four methods
- Receive individual written feedback
- Identify one technique and one water-reading priority
- Build a personal 30-day practice plan

ACTIVITIES

- Written instructor assessment: roll cast, leader build, swing control, dead drift line discipline, Wotton lift, contact coverage
- Individual feedback: one strength, one priority, one thing to practice on every outing
- Recommended reading: Nemes The Soft-Hackled Fly, Wotton Wet Fly Ways, Hughes Wet Flies
- 30-day plan: specific water type for each method, observation journal on take detection

✓ **Checkpoint:** Completed written assessment returned to each student. Instructor retains copy for program records.